4.1 A New Kind of Slavery

Hundreds of newly enslaved people chained together so they can barely move sounds horrifying, because it was. In the 1600s, Europeans seeking wealth in the Americas turned to an ancient and brutal practice: slavery.

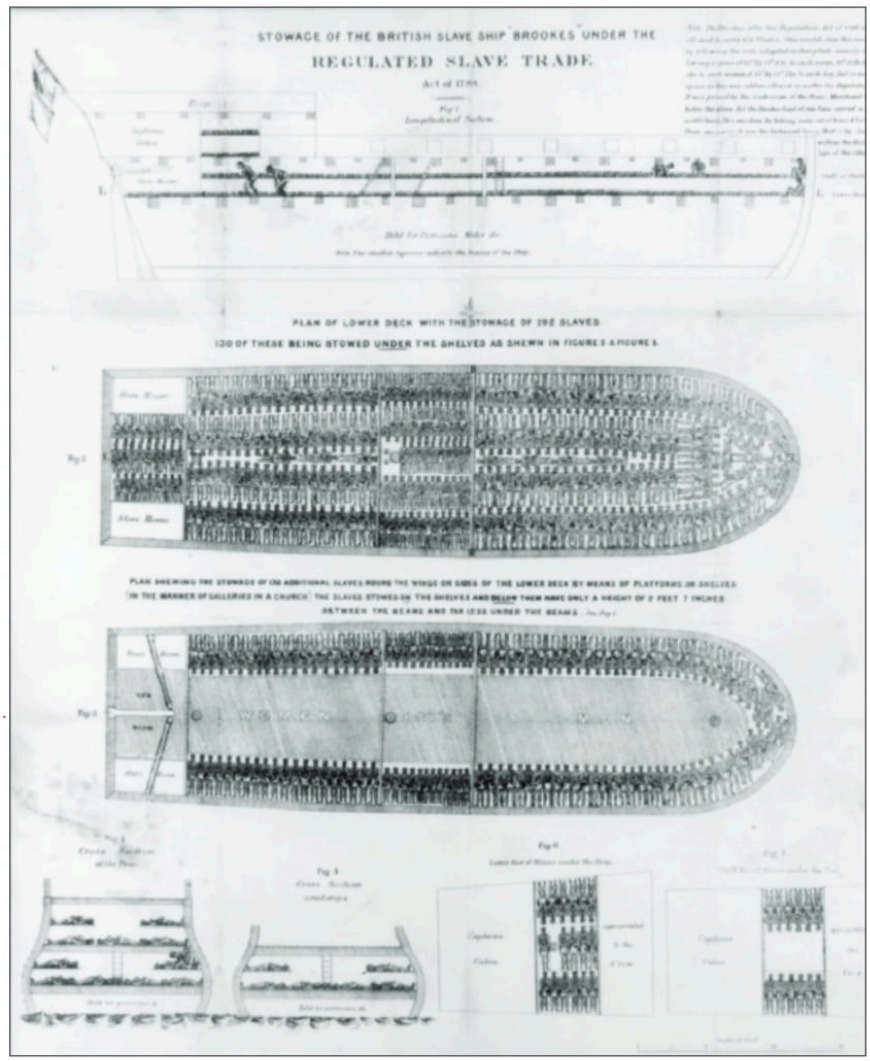
MAIN IDEA Demand for labor in Europe and the Americas drove the development of a new kind of slavery, beginning with the capture of people in West Africa.

A NEW FORM OF SLAVERY

Slavery is a social system in which human beings take complete control of others. It has existed throughout human history. In ancient societies around the world, prisoners of war were a main source of slaves. People also bonded themselves into slavery to pay off debts. Such slaves rarely stayed in bondage all their lives. They could usually buy or work for their freedom, and many of them had certain legal rights. Their children almost never became slaves themselves.

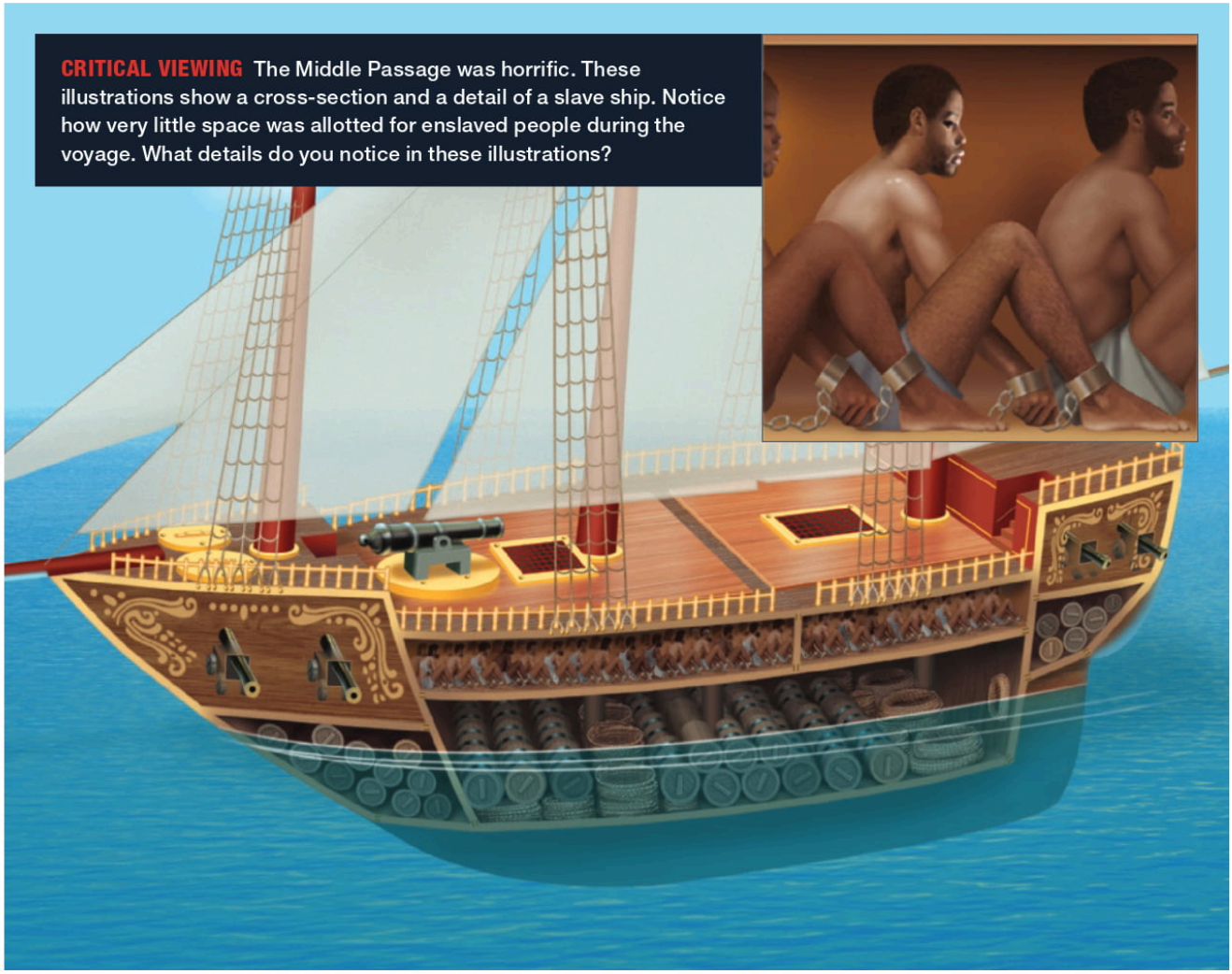
However, during European colonization of the Americas, a new kind of slavery developed. Under **chattel slavery**, people were classified as goods with virtually no human rights. Their bondage—and that of their children—was permanent.

Chattel slavery originated in the mid-1400s when the Portuguese started to trade with West African kingdoms for slaves to work on sugar plantations. Kingdoms such as Dahomey and Ashanti became powerful centers of slave trade commerce, partly by capturing people in raids on inland villages. Raiders marched captives in chains to the coast and locked them in holding pens. The slave traders exchanged goods for the newly enslaved people and shipped them across the Atlantic.



Slave Ship Diagram
The slave trade involved a lot of money and investment on the part of slave traders, merchants, and ship captains. This slave ship diagram shows the precise planning that went into transporting humans across the Atlantic Ocean.

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CRITICAL VIEWING The Middle Passage was horrific. These illustrations show a cross-section and a detail of a slave ship. Notice how very little space was allotted for enslaved people during the voyage. What details do you notice in these illustrations?

THE TRIANGULAR TRADE

As you read earlier in this chapter, the Columbian Exchange transformed the Americas and Europe through a massive transfer of plants, animals, and diseases. Another exchange also transformed the Americas, only this one included humans as goods. This exchange formed part of the **triangular trade**, a three-part system of trade that connected Europe, Africa, and the Americas during the 17th and 18th centuries.

In the first leg of the triangular trade route, traders from Europe brought goods to West Africa to exchange for captured and enslaved Africans. The second and most infamous leg was the **Middle Passage**. Slave traders forced enslaved Africans onto ships where they were confined in sickening, often fatal conditions. The 5,000-mile voyage took from three weeks to three months. Approximately 10 to 15 percent of the people held captive on slave ships died of disease or despair before reaching the Americas.

Once the ships reached port, the captured Africans were sold again or traded for goods. On the third leg of the voyage, ships loaded with products from the Americas returned to Europe, and the pattern repeated.

The triangular trade lasted until the slave trade was abolished in the early 1800s. Meanwhile, the people who were captured, transported, and sold were unlikely ever to taste freedom again.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** How was chattel slavery different from most forms of slavery practiced in ancient societies?
2. **SUMMARIZE** What was the triangular trade?
3. **INTEGRATE VISUALS** How would you describe the Middle Passage? Use details from the illustrations and the text in your description.

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